Contestable Cooperation

Operational capacity, corrective capacity, and the politics of evaluation

Systemic Optimization — Working Paper B1 · Discussion draft v0.5.1
11 November 2026
Status: Conceptual synthesis and assessment-design proposal. Not peer-reviewed. The proposed procedure has not been independently validated.
Research lineage: *Cooperation Without Reconciliation* (B0); SCI challenges and manuscript reflections through v0.4; bounded conceptual crosswalk with *Governance as Engineering*, Country Reports and the three *Self* working papers for v0.5.

Abstract

A cooperative arrangement can provide valuable shared goods while denying affected people meaningful control over its terms. Conversely, contestation may interrupt services without necessarily diminishing an arrangement's prospects for legitimate cooperation. This paper argues that assessment must distinguish **operational performance** (what coordination delivers), **corrective capacity** (whether affected people can safely surface problems, challenge their interpretation, obtain accountable decisions and change governing terms), and **normative acceptability** (whether those terms meet defensible standards of rights and non-domination). These properties interact, but none can be inferred from another. Building on established work in peace research, intergroup contact, republican political theory and conflict-sensitive assessment, the paper develops a second claim: **evaluation is itself an intervention**. Metrics and judgments can reward suppression of grievances as readily as their resolution, making an assessment's framing, incentives and contestability part of the object of inquiry. To operationalize these ideas, the paper proposes a provisional *Contestability Module* to extend, rather than replace, competent existing evaluation practice. It distinguishes directional power from outcomes and normative judgments, protects disagreement without treating allegations as automatically established, and tests whether institutions can revise not only decisions but also their **interpretations of what the problem is**. A bounded comparison with governance-engineering working papers motivates this interpretive requirement without claiming that a mathematical model proves it occurs in real institutions. A difficult hypothetical public-service case illustrates the trade-offs; a comparative evaluation design specifies how the module's claimed value could be rejected. The paper proposes no universal causal law, no aggregate peace score and no requirement that emotional reconciliation precede cooperation.

Keywords: intergroup cooperation; systemic optimization; correctability; non-domination; contestability; evaluation reactivity; conflict sensitivity; institutional adaptation

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1. The evaluation problem: two ways to get cooperation wrong

Two communities share a water system. It supplies safe water on schedule, its finances balance, and visible political conflict is limited. A performance review may correctly say that operational coordination is effective. It cannot conclude from those facts alone that the communities have equal influence over tariffs, that dissent is safe, or that people can challenge the rules without risking access to water or employment. Functioning can be real while the relationship governing it remains unequal.

Now suppose residents organize a boycott over tariff rules and service is interrupted. An assessment centered on uninterrupted delivery or low protest counts may register deterioration. That, too, may be an accurate observation at the level of immediate service delivery. Yet the political implication is indeterminate: the boycott could expose an injustice previously suppressed, create leverage for a better agreement, or instead impose

disproportionate costs on vulnerable people without improving accountability. **Disruption cannot by itself tell us whether a cooperative system is becoming more or less defensible.**

These examples capture two errors. A **false success** occurs when collaboration, attitudinal warmth or public calm is promoted to proof of consent, legitimacy or justice. A **false failure** occurs when legitimate challenge is counted as dysfunction merely because it disturbs a current arrangement. The solution is not to romanticize opposition or to disparage functioning services. It is to specify the property being judged, establish what evidence supports that judgment, and ask who can challenge the system—including the standards by which it is assessed.

This is not a new discovery that cooperation can precede reconciliation. Contact theory, peace research, instrumental reconciliation and agonistic political thought have long examined practical accommodation amid disagreement [1–3]. Nor is it new that peace can be unjust. The narrower contribution attempted here is an **evaluation argument**: an institution's ability to produce valuable coordination and its ability to correct its governing terms are distinct, potentially conflicting capacities; because evaluation changes actors' incentives, neither capacity should be judged from an uncontested performance indicator alone.

The discussion applies most directly to continuing institutional arrangements, such as shared services, municipal partnerships, workplaces, schools and power-sharing institutions. In post-atrocity settings, its insistence that emotional harmony is not a prerequisite for immediate joint activity must never be read as a waiver of acknowledgment, restitution, accountability or rights. Reconciliation has multiple meanings; this paper does not seek to settle them. Its larger motivating question is how people can continue acting together across real differences **without requiring disagreement to disappear or turning the ability to dissent into a threat to the whole relationship**.

2. Three properties of a cooperative arrangement

The organizing distinction is between **what an arrangement does**, **whether it can correct how it does it**, and **whether its terms are normatively acceptable**. These are not three ingredients of a single validated index. They are separate questions to which different evidence and standards apply.

2.1 Operational performance

Operational performance concerns the delivery of the intended goods: continuity, reliability, safety, accessibility, effectiveness, cost, and the distribution of these outcomes. In a shared water utility, it includes safe supply, maintenance and affordability; in an intergroup program it might include actual costly cooperation across group boundaries, rather than merely a stated willingness to cooperate. The relevant unit and task must be named. Performance should be measured at the levels of both the arrangement and its affected participants, with distributions visible rather than hidden in an average.

Good operational performance is valuable. An institution that cannot supply essential services may worsen distrust and expose people to serious harm. The argument of this paper does not treat service delivery as morally trivial, nor require withholding cooperation until every historical grievance is resolved. It rejects only the additional inference that delivery establishes political consent, equal standing or the capacity to alter unfair arrangements.

2.2 Corrective capacity

Corrective capacity is the practical ability of affected people to identify problems, communicate and challenge how those problems are understood, obtain accountable decisions, and secure warranted changes to an arrangement's rules or implementation without unacceptable retaliation. It is more than the formal existence of a complaints channel. It includes accessible information, meaningful standing, reasonably safe expression, contestable interpretation, independent review, responsiveness, enforceable remedies and protection from

unilateral rollback. Its quality can be investigated by following what happens to concrete grievances and how decisions change, not just by counting forms submitted or hearings held.

A useful analytical decomposition is a **correction chain**: **expression** (can the concern safely become available?), **interpretation** (can different accounts of its meaning be heard and challenged?), **adjudication** (can competing accounts receive an accountable, reviewable decision?), and **implementation and learning** (can justified decisions alter practice, with feedback on whether the remedy worked?). These stages are not a claim that all institutions follow one linear workflow: decisions may iterate, bypass stages in emergencies, or run through multiple parallel channels. The point is diagnostic. A system can receive every complaint yet classify objections to unequal decision authority as mere misunderstanding of technical constraints. It can correctly interpret a complaint but lack authority to act. It can order a remedy but leave the underlying rule unchanged. **Having a channel to speak is not equivalent to having a channel through which the institution's framing of the complaint can be challenged.**

Corrective capacity is not an unlimited right to stop every decision, an obligation to agree with each complaint, or a guarantee of perpetual re-negotiation. Competing claimants also have rights; infrastructure must be maintained; some harmful tactics may legitimately be restricted. A workable system needs procedures that can hear contestation, distinguish competing claims, reach timely decisions, enforce outcomes, and preserve essential coordination where possible. **Correction is a capacity to make justified change possible, not a requirement that every challenge succeeds.**

It also has a temporal dimension. A routine service may be judged over weeks while structural dependency accumulates over years. An annual audit cannot certify long-term correctability from a single quiet period. Historical rule changes, unresolved grievances, appeal outcomes, reprisals, changing entry and exit costs, and future review triggers all matter. Evidence about *interpretation* must include some record of how decision-makers classified the original concern and whether a substantively different characterization was permitted to affect the review; it should not rest on an assessor's speculative diagnosis of anyone's private motives.

2.3 Technical and political correctability

Technical correctability concerns whether an institution can detect errors, revise methods or governing assumptions, implement changes, and learn from their consequences. **Political correctability** concerns whether people subject to its decisions can meaningfully challenge its problem definitions, objectives, and governing rules, and influence accountable reconsideration. Neither guarantees the other: an institution may adapt skillfully while keeping its agenda closed to those it governs; meaningful participation, in turn, does not by itself supply the resources or expertise needed to implement justified decisions.

Argyris and Schön's distinction between *single-loop* and *double-loop* organizational learning [32] clarifies one side of this boundary. Single-loop learning corrects action within prevailing governing norms; double-loop learning questions or modifies the norms themselves. Yet even effective double-loop learning can remain **politically closed** if only incumbents may initiate, frame, or decide which governing assumptions to revise. The additional requirement concerns legitimate standing and consequential influence over that process, not simply a more sophisticated technical learning mechanism.

Fricker's account of *epistemic injustice* [33] illuminates failures at the **interpretation** link of the correction chain. A person's report can receive unjustly diminished credibility because of prejudice (*testimonial injustice*), or an important experience can be obscured by unfair gaps in shared interpretive resources (*hermeneutical injustice*). Not every disputed classification is unjust: evidence and competing claims still require assessment. The procedural test is whether affected people can challenge the **classification of their grievance**, receive reasons and independent review, and establish whether subsequent adjudication and implementation address the concern they raised. **Expression without contestable interpretation can leave a technically responsive complaints system politically closed.**

2.4 Normative acceptability

Normative acceptability asks whether the *terms* of cooperation satisfy a declared and defended standard. This paper uses a provisional specification: basic rights and safety, meaningful remedy, and republican **non-domination**, understood as protection against another actor's unchecked capacity for arbitrary interference [13,14]. This standard is an argued normative choice, not a finding derivable from public-goods games or surveys. Rival specifications—for example, outcome-prioritizing humanitarianism, deliberative legitimacy or more agonistic accounts—must be describable and their implications discussable.

The distinction between interference and domination matters. An authority may never have cut off water to dissenters but may possess unconstrained power to do so. Under a non-domination standard, the **capacity** for arbitrary deprivation is relevant even without an observed exercise of that power [13]. Conversely, a rule-governed restriction with independent review need not be dominating merely because it interferes with a chosen action. That is why silence, lack of recorded sanctions and absence of formal complaints cannot be treated as proof of freedom or consent. Work on preference falsification and public versus hidden transcripts offers independent reasons for caution about what people say under unequal power [18,19].

This point is especially important inside groups. 'Community A' and 'Community B' are not natural homogeneous agents. Internal factions, women, minorities, newcomers and nonparticipants may face subordination by elites who claim to speak on the group's behalf. Identifying group boundaries, representatives and excluded people is an **object of evaluation**, not a neutral preliminary assumption.

2.5 Keep the judgments—and their evidence—separate

A strong evidence claim about service reliability does not settle legitimacy; a convincing rights concern does not establish that every aspect of service delivery failed. For a given arrangement, the proposed record therefore distinguishes substantive assessments from the *status of their evidence*:

Property assessed	Example finding	What remains a separate question
Operational performance	Reliable, affordable water delivery over a specified period	Who can change tariffs or allocation rules?
Corrective capacity	Appeals exist, but no independent power to enforce remedies is documented	What happens when a contested decision is challenged?
Normative acceptability	One party retains unchecked discretion to withdraw essential service	Has this power been exercised, and how do affected parties experience it?
Evidence status, attached to each claim	Supported; provisional; contested; insufficient	A confidence label is **not** a moral verdict

Normative findings may be recorded as *meets the specified threshold*, *fails it*, *indeterminate*, or *transitionally deficient under stated conditions*, with reasons and competing judgments preserved. These are **not substitutes for the underlying three property assessments**. A provisional overall recommendation—for instance, "continue emergency delivery, but transfer tariff review to an independent body"—must be transparently constructed from the separate findings rather than obtained by adding them into a score.

A second distinction concerns the unit of inference. A group-average association cannot establish every individual's experience. Direction matters: one group can cooperate with another while receiving less consideration in return; one party can fear the other without reciprocal fear. Behavioral cooperation, reported intention, threat perception, documented danger, discretionary power and normative rights are different sorts of evidence. They should not be drawn as if they were interchangeable measurements of a single 'relationship quality' variable.

3. Established insights, evidence boundaries and the specific gap

3.1 The literature already warns against equating calm with peace

Galtung's distinction between negative and positive peace directs attention beyond an absence of overt violence to structural conditions [1]. Reconciliation literature distinguishes instrumental cooperation from socio-emotional processes [2], and political accounts allow disagreement to remain part of legitimate common life [3]. The intergroup contact literature has likewise debated whether prejudice reduction is an adequate target for structural change. Saguy and colleagues' *irony of harmony* work suggests that under some conditions improved intergroup contact can reduce disadvantaged groups' willingness to challenge inequality [6]. These are antecedents, not discoveries of this paper.

Conflict-sensitive assessment also has mature approaches. The Do No Harm (DNH) framework already considers dividers, connectors, resource transfers, implicit messages and the effects of interventions on conflict dynamics [7]. Peace-and-conflict impact assessment (PCIA) and bottom-up peace indicators likewise contest narrow, imposed success measures [8,20]. A competent assessor using these practices may already examine who benefits, who is excluded and whether grievances can surface. **The proposed addition therefore cannot claim that power, participation or unintended effects were previously ignored.** Its potential difference lies in making specific inferential and contestation requirements explicit, testable and adaptable to routine institutional evaluation.

3.2 Behavior and attitudes need different measurements

Field experiments help show why outcomes must be stated concretely. Scacco and Warren's contact intervention in Nigeria examined discrimination and prejudice separately, finding changes in some discriminatory behavior without correspondingly broad changes in reported prejudice [4]. Mousa's randomized mixed-team soccer intervention in post-ISIS Iraq improved certain behavioral interactions with Muslim teammates, while wider attitudinal and out-of-setting changes were limited or inconsistent [5]. Neither finding licenses the inference that a positive game outcome demonstrates just institutional design. Both make it difficult to justify using an attitude scale as a stand-in for all cooperative outcomes.

Schäfer and colleagues' 2026 survey across 12 European countries found associations between perceived inclusivity norms and stated willingness to cooperate across strongly disapproved opinion differences [9]. A B0 secondary analysis of the deposited responses found these associations positive across several weighting and covariate specifications [B0a]. The result concerns self-reports in a cross-sectional survey, not observed costly cooperation or causal buffering under existential threat. Preserving that distinction is more useful than inflating a correlational result into a universal rule.

3.3 Cooperation can coexist with threats and unequal relationships

Schaub's lab-in-the-field research in six Georgian villages recorded public-goods cooperation as well as perceived-threat and aggressive choices in a separate *threat game* [10]. The study reports heightened ingroup-oriented and aggressive behavior in communities more exposed to ethnic outsiders, yet also substantial outgroup cooperation. This is compatible with strategic tension management: offering cooperation to keep mutually beneficial exchange open while maintaining hostile or defensive postures. It is **not** evidence that cooperation establishes reconciliation, nor that threat promotes just cooperation. The B0 reanalysis found a negative within-village individual association between outgroup cooperation and one threat-game measure, but that result is exploratory; six villages cannot support strong exposure-level causal inference [B0b].

Chang and Peisakhin's Lebanon experiment distinguished forms of intersectarian cooperation and showed that a civic-identity expert appeal improved some unconditional choices without neutralizing sectarian clientelistic incentives [11]. A shared identity can be a useful mechanism without being universally necessary. The kind of cooperation, and the incentives around it, matter. Raffoul's comparative analysis of Burundi and Northern Ireland similarly emphasizes the practice of power sharing—interpretation of rules, elite socialization and

representation—not merely formal institutional architecture [12]. Neither study identifies an institutional recipe sufficient for legitimate cooperation.

This paper carries one bounded inference from the evidence: **an observed cooperative outcome underdetermines the arrangement's power relations, legitimacy and capacity for correction**. Much existing scholarship says similar things. The specific task here is to articulate what an evaluation must then keep distinct, how evaluation may worsen those errors, and how a small procedural supplement might be tested against competent alternatives.

3.4 Match claims to the design that can support them

The B0 research distinguished three claims relevant to cooperation amid perceived threat: **coexistence** in a specified time and unit; **persistence** across repeated observations; and **institutional buffering**, a causal claim that an institutional feature changes how threat affects behavior. A cross-section may support coexistence, repeated measures are required for persistence, and buffering requires credible identifying variation rather than mere statistical interaction. None of these constructs guarantees justice, and no dataset examined in B0 directly identifies all the proposed dynamic relations. Friehs and colleagues' methodological comparison of longitudinal models reinforces the danger of treating panel associations as causal effects without identifying assumptions [21].

This three-way distinction remains an **inference discipline**, not the main theory of Paper 1. Detailed recovery, tipping and hysteresis hypotheses belong to later work if suitable measurement and identification become available.

3.5 A bounded connection to governance engineering and human interpretation

A related set of *Governance as Engineering* (GaE) working papers offers conceptual tools for this evaluation problem, but **not independent empirical confirmation**. *Requisite Alignment* (XXVII) demonstrates within an exactly solved control problem that an informative signal can have reduced decision value when it resolves a distinction misaligned with the action-relevant target [23]. For a public-service evaluation, this motivates the question whether an accurate delivery indicator is aligned with a decision about **whose rules govern delivery**. The formal model proves its result for its specified controller; applying it to institutions is an analogy and design hypothesis, not a theorem about municipalities.

The Observer You Cannot Afford to Excite (XXIV) explores how observation, access to informative alternatives and adaptive performance interact in a minimal computational system [24]. *When to Stop Learning, and When to Stop* (XXI) distinguishes improved internal learning from effective coupling and argues against treating institutional persistence as an unconditional goal [25]. These are useful prompts for asking whether an evaluation preserves opportunities to detect alternative arrangements, but their model-dependent results cannot establish an empirical suppression loop in any particular society.

The *Self* trilogy extends the question to human observers. *Self I* treats an individual's value commitments as attentional filters; *Self II* explores the reflexive possibility that attending to a state helps change it; *Self III: The Operator* proposes that interpretive blind spots at human decision nodes may shape the institutional view of the governed [26–28]. **Our narrower inference** is conditional: if officials have decisive interpretive control over a complaint and there is no effective route around that interpretation, an otherwise adequate complaints procedure can fail at the interpretation stage. We do not infer from the trilogy that a person's introspective ability is measurable as a general observability rank, that self-awareness is necessary for recognizing another person's grievance, or that better personal development alone secures rights. These claims would need independent evidence.

The Country Reports for Sweden, Japan and Russia propose contrasting diagnoses of competent routine delivery, continuity-biased adaptation and dangerous feedback channels [29–31]. Their qualitative diagnoses illustrate **questions to investigate**—not validated comparative cases, independent replications or proof of the present thesis. Because they are author-curated and, in parts, AI-generated interpretive reports with unverified

claims, the present argument does not rest on their country-level accuracy. It rests on the distinction between what can be performed, what can be recognized and revised, and who is entitled to challenge the interpretation.

4. The systemic problem: evaluation changes what it measures

Suppose an authority is rewarded for uninterrupted service and falling protest counts. A governance dashboard assigns a favorable grade when both indicators improve. If the authority can influence how grievances are categorized, who is permitted to demonstrate or how publicly complaints are recorded, it may be rewarded for making dissent less visible rather than solving the underlying dispute. Reduced protest can strengthen funding, prestige or discretionary authority, which in turn supports the same behavior. This is a *candidate reinforcing loop*: performance incentives → reduced visibility of grievances → reported success → stronger incumbent incentives. It is an application of a broader literature on the reactivity of evaluation, not a newly established empirical law [16,17].

The mechanism requires several links, which can be investigated rather than assumed: a measurable reward or sanction attached to the metric; meaningful discretion over recording or suppressing disagreement; an observable change in complaint access or sanction practices; persistence of unaddressed grievances; and a feedback channel from favorable ratings to resources or authority. Evidence against the suppression account might include independent grievance records, genuinely improved conditions, protected opportunities for objection, and documented resolution of the underlying complaints. Lower protest can represent a successful settlement as well as coercive quiet.

A possible **correction pathway** runs differently: accessible information and protected challenge reveal defects; independent review distinguishes justified from unjustified claims; enforceable remedies alter rules or their implementation; participants can renew operational cooperation on more defensible terms. This pathway can fail through captured reviewers, strategic obstruction, unfunded remedies or impossible demands. What matters is that the arrangement has a capacity to process challenge, **not** that complaint rates rise or every challenge wins.

Two further failures can arise **before** a grievance reaches an outcome metric. First, the indicator may be accurate but **irrelevant to the disputed decision**: uninterrupted supply says little about who can unilaterally change tariffs or sanction objectors. Second, officials may interpret an objection through a frame that precludes the relevant political question: a request to share authority is recoded as a failure of public understanding, or justified technical uncertainty is dismissed as malicious obstruction. These are different errors. The first concerns the relation of evidence to the decision target; the second concerns an institution's **contestable classification** of what the grievance is about. Different reviewers might legitimately reach different conclusions. What matters is whether the competing descriptions can be heard, evidenced and resolved without one actor acquiring an unreviewable monopoly over the categories.

An interpretive bottleneck is testable in principle. Case records can compare an initial complaint, the authority's recorded classification, an independent account, the reasons offered for accepting or rejecting each, and any change in remedies. Rival explanations include accurate technical triage, genuine resource scarcity, strategic misrepresentation by claimants, and disagreement about values rather than a hidden perceptual failure. It would be improper to infer an official's psychology merely from a policy decision. **The institutional safeguard is plural and accountable interpretive access, not a requirement that every official be unusually insightful.**

The paths may have different time constants. Daily water delivery, annual performance ratings and decades-long entrenchment of political privilege do not evolve on the same schedule. A short-lived improvement in delivery or a prolonged absence of protest cannot alone certify that corrective capacity is improving. Historical changes in discretion, exclusion, remedies and representation should be examined against a declared observation horizon.

An additional reflexive problem follows: **an audit can be gamed in the same way as the dashboard it replaces**. Authorities may create token grievance channels that resolve nothing; funders may commission the review to legitimate a preferred outcome; challengers may fabricate or strategically package claims; assessors may define group boundaries in ways that privilege local elites. Counting the number of grievance offices or

completed audits could then become a new proxy error. Verification must follow complaint trajectories and institutional changes, compare sources independently where safe, and record who commissioned the assessment, controlled evidence and could prevent publication. Silence can be informative only with extreme caution; a structurally unchecked power is observable even where fearful people cannot testify against it.

This is the systemic contribution Paper 1 attempts: **the choice of evaluative objective, the allocation of framing power and the possibility of correcting the evaluative objective jointly shape the system being optimized**. It does not require a fitted differential equation to be a coherent design problem. It does require testable links, rival explanations and safeguards against making the evaluator a new source of domination.

5. A defensible normative floor and a corrective trajectory

Assessment requires a declared normative standard. Our provisional standard is non-domination coupled with a basic rights floor and effective remedies. It is grounded in republican political theory [13,14] and informed by human-rights protections for remedies, expression, peaceful assembly and association [15]. The relevant legal duties depend on jurisdiction, actors and circumstances; this paper is not a legal determination of any particular dispute. Principles on effective grievance mechanisms can also guide institutional assessment: the UN Guiding Principles on Business and Human Rights identify legitimacy, accessibility, predictability, equity, transparency, rights compatibility, learning and engagement as effectiveness considerations [22]. Their direct legal and institutional application varies; we use them here as a relevant source of design criteria, not as a claim that every water partnership is a business enterprise.

A **two-tier structure** avoids pretending that every injustice can be resolved before essential cooperation continues.

Tier 1: a rights and safety floor. The arrangement and the assessment should not rely on serious threats to basic safety, arbitrary deprivation of essential goods, or retaliation against legitimately protected expression and access to remedy. Restrictions on conduct—including particular forms of protest—must be assessed under applicable law, with attention to legitimate purpose, necessity, proportionality and independent review. This is a threshold on *how cooperation may be governed*, not a claim that all disruption is protected or all state interference is domination. Credible evidence of an unchecked capacity to impose serious sanctions should trigger scrutiny before affected people are asked to provide dangerous testimony proving actual retaliation.

Tier 2: a corrective trajectory above the floor. An imperfect settlement can remain valuable and temporarily necessary, especially when immediate failure would cause grave harm. But its deficiencies should not be renamed success. A defensible transitional judgment asks: Which unequal powers are necessary for which functions? Who bears the resulting burdens? What review and sunset conditions exist? Who can initiate review, veto changes, appeal decisions and obtain resources for participation? Which outcomes or milestones must change, and what happens if they do not? Can the process be blocked indefinitely by the party benefiting from the status quo? An arrangement that makes real correction possible differs from one that merely promises eventual fairness while locking in unilateral control.

These rules do not solve every conflict. A consociational settlement can protect one set of groups against domination while empowering their elites over internal minorities. Emergency service delivery may demand centralized technical control before representative governance becomes feasible. The assessor should record such trade-offs explicitly, identify non-negotiable protections that remain in force, and apply a burden of justification to those exercising exceptional power. A *provisional, normatively deficient but correctable* assessment is a meaningful conclusion; it is neither uncritical endorsement nor a demand to shut down life-saving cooperation.

Corrective capacity does not give an institution a license to reinterpret protected opposition as pathology, irrationality or disloyalty. An operator may sincerely believe a challenge is misunderstood, strategically motivated or rooted in fear; that belief is not an authoritative substitute for examining the claimant's own account, independent evidence and relevant legal entitlements. Nor does the claimant's first-person report automatically settle a dispute over facts, resources or rights. **Interpretive pluralism is a procedural**

safeguard: allow contestable competing accounts, require reasons for decisions and make framing errors reviewable without making subjective experience a compulsory disclosure requirement.

Finally, standards themselves must be open to reasoned contest. Affected participants should be able to challenge the interpretation of a rights provision or a non-domination claim, and competent assessors should disclose how rival normative frameworks would alter their judgment. Protected participation does not give any claimant an automatic presumption of truth. It gives them a safe and meaningful opportunity to have their claims tested against consistent criteria.

6. The proposed Contestability Module

The **Contestability Module (CM)** is a provisional addition to an existing conflict-sensitive review, public-service evaluation or governance assessment. It is **not** a validated independent 'Relational Viability Audit', a substitute for expert DNH/PCIA practice, or a universal peace index. Its aim is to make four possible assessment failures harder to overlook: invalid inference from indicators, unexamined discretionary power, **non-contestable interpretation of grievances**, and the evaluator's own contribution to suppressing correction.

6.1 Minimal record and escalation

A lightweight initial review should record the arrangement, decision, affected people and possible nonparticipants, timeframe, operational results, decision authority, sources of evidence, how concerns are categorized, and the applicable normative floor. It should then address five tests; serious rights concerns, disputed representation, interpretive monopoly or retaliation risks trigger a more independent and protected assessment. In urgent situations the process may proceed in stages, without halting essential services while facts are gathered, provided immediate safeguards remain in force.

CM test	Required record	What it prevents or makes contestable
1. Specify the claim and signal	Outcome, affected unit, direction, period, comparator, evidence strength; why the indicator is relevant to this decision	Promoting willingness into behavior, indicator movement into legitimacy, or a correct measurement into a relevant one
2. Trace control and distribution	Benefits and burdens; who can set terms, sanction, withhold goods, exit or compel review; internal group dissent	Mistaking exchange or visible silence for symmetric consent
3. Trace the correction chain	Safe expression, initial classification of concerns, independent adjudication, implemented remedies, review of actual rule changes	Equating complaint reception or favorable closure counts with recognized and corrected grievances
4. Protect challenges to interpretation	Alternative framing supplied by affected people or independent advocate; evidence, reasons for rejection or adoption, safe dissent record	Letting the commissioning or dominant party monopolize the account; treating every allegation as fact
5. Audit the assessment itself	Sponsor and funding, framing and publication control, metrics' effects, retaliatory or strategic use, bypass channels and follow-up triggers	Replacing a captured dashboard with a captured audit

The output is a **three-property judgment**, accompanied by separate *evidence-status* and *normative-status* fields for each consequential proposition. It should name responsible decision makers, feasible corrective actions, unresolved issues and review dates; it does not generate an aggregate 'peace score'. Where safety prevents meaningful participation, the constraint and the structural evidence available must be recorded rather than falsely interpreting absent testimony as approval.

A protected adverse reading need not force vulnerable people to appear publicly or repeatedly relive trauma. Independent representation, secure channels, safe document review or an external advocate may be more

appropriate. Crucially, the *affected person's interpretation of their own grievance* is not automatically correct about every fact, but it must not be silently replaced by an incumbent's supposedly neutral classification. The assessor should preserve disputed framings and give reasons that can be appealed or independently tested. The assessor must also examine whether factional actors are using the process to suppress internal rivals, manufacture allegations or hijack the framing. Competing claims should be assessed with comparable evidentiary standards, while acknowledging that unequal access to records and retaliation risk can make nominal symmetry unfair in practice.

6.2 What could this add to existing practice?

The relevant comparator depends on context. A municipal dashboard may report service and complaint counts but have little structured analysis of domination. A **competently performed** DNH or PCIA assessment is already much more sophisticated. The CM can be justified only if its explicit procedures improve decisions relative to the comparator actually used.

Comparison practice	What it can already do	Proposed CM emphasis	Incremental value still unproven
Routine operational dashboard	Measure outputs, continuity, budgets, complaints	Separate performance from correctability; trace whether grievance classifications and remedies are reviewable; examine metric incentives	May reveal risks missed by output-only evaluation
Competent DNH/PCIA	Analyze conflict drivers, beneficiaries, intervention effects and power	Mandatory claim-typing, structural discretion and interpretive-monopoly checks, safe adverse reading and audit-reactivity record	Could add little beyond good existing practice
Participatory / bottom-up assessment	Bring affected perspectives into indicator definition	Track whether dissent changes decisions and whether auditors can be challenged	Must avoid replacing participation with another formal ritual

The CM's distinctive **proposal** is less a new list of social goods than a rule about *how an evaluator must justify and reopen its judgments*. Even that procedural combination may already be present elsewhere. It deserves comparative testing, not an assumed monopoly on good assessment.

7. A difficult worked case: a valuable service on unequal terms

Consider the following **hypothetical case**, constructed to expose competing considerations rather than represent a real community. Two municipalities depend on a joint water utility. Municipality A owns much of the technical infrastructure, contributes most of the engineering expertise, guarantees emergency financing and can stabilize service after severe breakdowns. Municipality B contains more low-income households, has fewer alternative water sources and would be disproportionately harmed by supply interruptions. A's administrators hold a majority of board votes and unilateral emergency powers; B has seats but no independent mechanism for contesting tariff decisions. Both populations receive safe water at prices below the cost of maintaining separate systems. A's technicians have acted competently and no arbitrary disconnection of B households has been documented.

Residents of B now demand greater influence over pricing. A argues that technical responsibility and financial liability justify its control. B argues that the absence of unilateral punishment so far does not make its dependence politically acceptable. A boycott would endanger financially vulnerable households; immediate dissolution of the joint utility might threaten basic safety. A compromise may therefore be necessary even if the present voting arrangement is normatively deficient.

Suppose B's residents submit a petition stating that the central issue is **who has the right to decide tariffs**, not merely the level of the tariff. A's administrator classifies the petition as a request for a technical explanation of

infrastructure costs and marks it resolved after publishing an accessible, accurate accounting of the expenses. This could be a good-faith response to a *different* question, not proof of malicious intent or of a defective cost estimate. But if residents cannot contest the classification, the official grievance channel may report success while leaving the governing-power grievance untouched. An independent reviewer should test both interpretations: whether the proposed rule change overlooks genuine engineering and financing obligations, and whether those obligations have been improperly treated as reasons to deny any political review. The decisive evidence concerns **complaint wording, the record of classification, independent reasons and reviewable authority**—not a speculative diagnosis of the administrator's psychology.

A narrow performance review may correctly identify that the utility works and should continue. A competent conflict-sensitive assessment may already flag the power imbalance, relative risks and divisive tariff politics. The CM would add a **required separation of conclusions** rather than a predetermined answer:

- **Operational performance:** strong on continuity, but check who bears future maintenance costs, risks and affordability burdens. Continued emergency supply may be an immediate priority.
- **Corrective capacity:** weak unless B can contest how its complaint is classified and obtain binding, independently reviewable decisions about tariffs and emergency powers. The key structural questions are whether A can arbitrarily punish challenge, indefinitely block revision, **or define a governance grievance out of existence as a technical information request**—not merely whether disconnection has occurred.
- **Normative acceptability:** potentially below the declared non-domination threshold; the conclusion depends on the scope of A's discretion, legal safeguards, necessity of emergency powers and available remedies. Technical expertise alone does not imply unbounded governing entitlement.
- **Evidence status:** observed delivery may be supported, while claims about residents' satisfaction, strategic motivations or retaliation risk may be contested or insufficient. A's own account and B's complaints must both be examined without requiring dangerous testimony.

A provisional decision might be to **maintain essential operations while imposing immediate safeguards on discretionary disconnections and retaliation**, establish independent tariff and complaint-classification review with accessible appeal, require a transparent examination of technical costs *and* governing authority, and adopt enforceable milestones for revising voting and emergency powers. Emergency technical command could continue under reviewable, narrowly defined conditions; a permanent veto over political revision would not be justified by the mere presence of expertise. Whether any particular timetable is adequate would depend on evidence about costs, safety, and legal obligations, not on a universal deadline invented by the audit.

The arrangement could thus be **operationally effective, normatively deficient, and provisionally correctable**. These findings are not logically contradictory. The same case could also support a different conclusion under better evidence—for example, if B actually possesses independent enforceable safeguards not visible in the initial description, or if the proposed power transfer jeopardizes safe supply and no feasible alternative exists. The assessment must state what facts would change its recommendation.

This example cannot prove the module adds value. A trained DNH/PCIA practitioner might reach an equally nuanced decision. Its purpose is to show what the manuscript's main distinction entails under a genuine trade-off: **do not endanger valuable cooperation unnecessarily, but do not purchase operational continuity by making correction impossible**.

8. Testing the proposal and setting limits

The CM's comparative design claim is testable. A preregistered assessor study could supply the same realistic, mixed-evidence case dossiers to evaluators using (a) a normal public-sector performance review, (b) competent DNH/PCIA, and (c) the same relevant method with the CM added. Fair comparisons require suitable training, balanced resources, transparent assessor selection and recognition that participants' prior expertise may affect results. The reference standard should be established independently, with uncertainty recorded rather than invented certainty about hidden motives.

Key outcomes would include accurate distinction of observed cooperation from stated willingness, identification of unchecked sanction authority even without reported punishment, detection of **interpretive misclassification without falsely imputing motives**, correct treatment of lawful protest and unlawful intimidation, recognition of legitimate operational benefits, appropriate recommendations for effective remedies, sensitivity to contested intra-group representation, inter-rater consistency, assessor burden and informant safety. Crucially, an intervention's success must not be measured only by **whether a grievance mechanism exists**; investigators should follow whether claims can be raised safely, adjudicated fairly and translated into enforced changes. Longer follow-up should examine whether the review itself alters reporting, retaliation or access to correction.

If the CM merely repeats findings of competent DNH/PCIA, produces more false positives or false accusations, compromises sources, or imposes costs disproportionate to any improvement, its separate identity should be dropped or its components incorporated into existing methods. A weak or null result would be informative. To test the new interpretation requirement specifically, the dossier set should include some cases where a technical classification is warranted and others where it conceals a rule-governance claim, with independent evidence available to assessors; otherwise the test would simply reward labeling every grievance political. The conceptual distinction between performance and correctability does not depend on the success of this particular module.

Several boundaries remain. There is no universal observational measure of threat, recognition, operator comprehension or domination; power may operate informally, and records can be strategically produced. The correction chain is a proposed diagnostic decomposition, not a validated process model. A human operator is a *potential* bottleneck, not necessarily the only channel through which people can communicate complex or interior experiences. The formal results invoked from GaE operate under model-specific assumptions; in linear dynamical systems a rank-deficient instantaneous sensor need not make the full system unobservable if subsequent observations and dynamics recover the state. Neither the Self trilogy's psychological mappings nor the Country Reports independently verify the institutional hypotheses advanced here. The B0 evidence includes cross-sectional studies, heterogeneous experiments and qualitative institutional analyses; no direct data analysis in this paper identifies cooperative persistence under sustained threat, causal institutional buffering or hysteresis. The feedback pathways in Section 4 are causal **hypotheses** requiring observational or experimental discrimination. Human-rights and non-domination judgments require competent contextual interpretation, including disagreements about whose safety and rights are affected. This paper does not resolve the optimal sequencing of peace and justice in particular conflicts.

The planned later research on group identity, perceived threat and antagonistic feedback can ask how social boundaries acquire hostile meanings and whether institutions interrupt that recursion. It should not be treated as a promised derivation of the present argument. Paper 1 stands or falls on the quality of its distinctions, its ability to clarify real evaluation decisions, and the feasibility of testing its procedural proposal.

9. Conclusion

Cooperation is an achievement worth preserving, especially where distrust and real differences persist. But a cooperative system is not fully understood by observing what it delivers today. We must also ask whether those governed by its rules can safely challenge them and whether the resulting decisions satisfy defensible rights and non-domination standards. A protest may reduce operational performance while improving the possibility of legitimate correction; smooth delivery may coexist with unchecked arbitrary authority. Neither pattern warrants an automatic verdict.

Operational performance, corrective capacity and normative acceptability are distinct but interacting properties. Corrective capacity includes the ability to challenge not only decisions but also an institution's account of what a grievance *means*. This paper's principal systemic claim is that evaluation can alter all three properties by influencing what is visible, what earns reward, who holds framing power and which grievances become actionable. The proposed Contestability Module makes that insight into a practical, falsifiable design proposal. It may improve routine institutional evaluation; it may add little to competent existing conflict-sensitive practice. Either outcome should be learned from rather than concealed.

The deeper question remains how people can act together without requiring an enemy, and disagree without being forced into hostility. This paper offers an institutional counterpart: how to sustain valuable coordination **without disabling the capacity to change its terms**. The final test of systemic optimization is not a permanently smooth indicator. It is the continuing ability to ask, with affected people able to answer and correct the result: **what are we optimizing, on whose terms, and who can correct us when the objective is wrong?**

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B0 evidence audit (exploratory, not independently peer-reviewed):

- **[B0a]** *B0 Secondary Analysis v0.4*. Re-analysis of Schäfer et al.'s deposited data: positive norm–cooperation-willingness associations under several exploratory specifications; not a behavioral or causal replication.
- **[B0b]** *B0 D01/D02 Archive Audit v0.6*. Exploratory Schaub re-analysis: within-village and aggregate correlations, with six-village inference limits and careful distinction between threat-game behavior and psychological threat.

Research status and next investigation boundaries

This is a conceptual **discussion draft**, not a validated tool, an empirical longitudinal model, a legal opinion or a claim of originality for established peacebuilding distinctions. This iteration integrates conditional connections to GaE and the *Self* trilogy and diagnoses possible interpretive bottlenecks; it does not claim that those author-origin sources independently validate one another. Claims of incremental assessment value require testing with skilled practitioners; normative and institutional arguments require further challenge in concrete settings. These boundaries are consolidated here rather than repeated as a disclaimer in every section.